Department of Media Studies & Journalism

Assignment Title: Final Report
Course Code: MSJ 3253
Course Title: Data Journalism
Section: 01

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Submission Date: 22.12.25

From Cinema Halls to Phone Screens: How Bangladesh Changed the Way It Watches Movies

In the late 1990s, a Friday evening at the Balaka or Modhumita cinema hall in Dhaka was an experience. It was the smell of damp seats mixed with fresh singaras, the heat of a thousand bodies pressed together, and the deafening, collective whistle of the crowd when the hero first stepped onto the screen. It was a loud, messy, communal ritual.

Fast forward to 2024. The same people who once queued for hours for a ticket are now watching movies in silence. They are staring at 6-inch screens, earphones plugged in, illuminated by the blue light of a smartphone while stuck in traffic.

This report explores a major change in Bangladeshi life: we have moved from the collective roar of the theater to the quiet solitude of the smartphone.

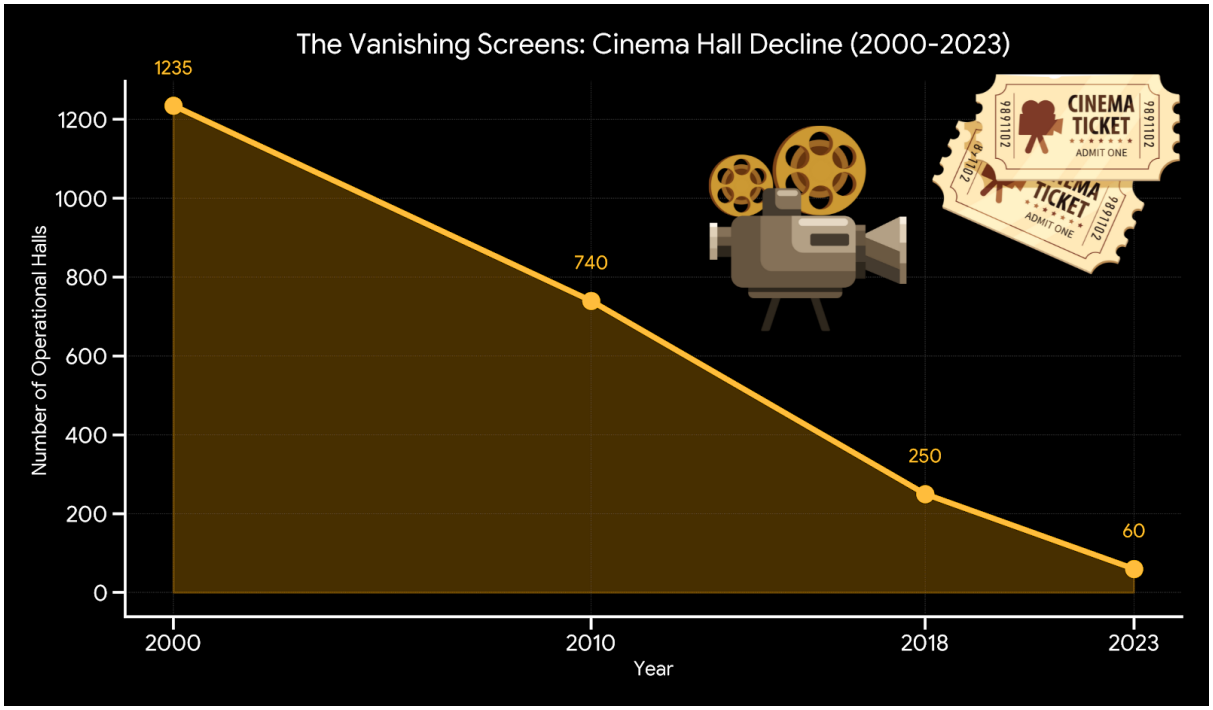
For decades, the single-screen cinema hall was the heart of entertainment in Bangladesh. From the busy streets of Dhaka to the quiet towns of Bogura and Jessore, the cinema hall was the only place for a family outing.

Between the 1980s and the late 1990s, the industry produced over 100 films a year. The cinema hall was a democratic space where a rickshaw puller and a university student could sit under the same roof and enjoy the same story.

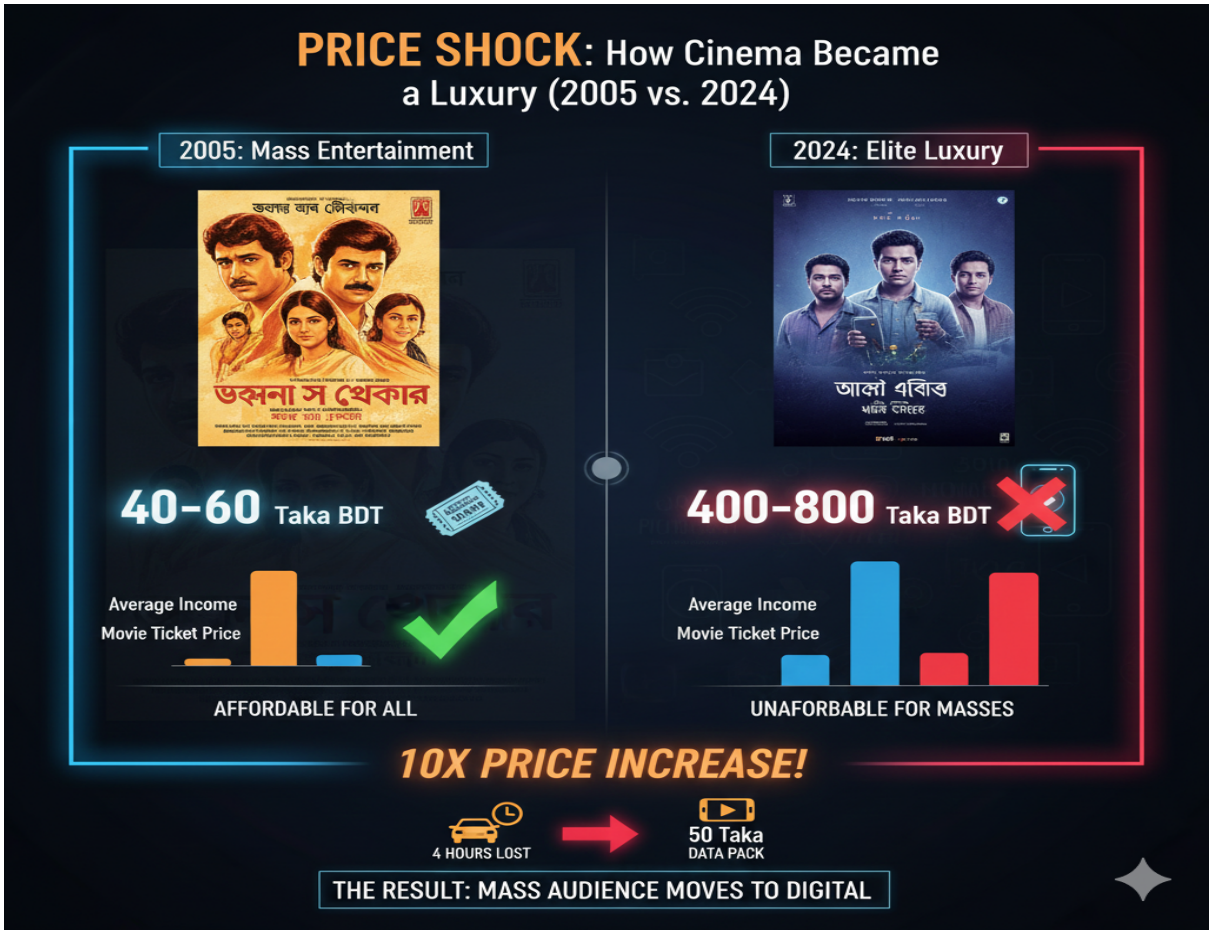
"Going to the cinema wasn't just about the movie; it was a social event. If you hadn't seen the Friday release, you had nothing to talk about at the tea stall on Sunday." - Dr. Anisul Hoque, Cultural Commentator

However, as time went on, old halls stopped renovating, piracy increased, and the quality of movies dropped. This began the slow death of cinema culture.

The data regarding physical cinema infrastructure in Bangladesh paints a stark picture of near-extinction. According to the Bangladesh Motion Picture Exhibitor Association, the number of operational cinema halls has plummeted by over 90% in the last two decades.



The closure rate was highest between 2010 and 2015, correlating with the rise of satellite TV and early internet piracy. While Dhaka retains a few modern multiplexes like Star Cineplex, entire districts have become "cinema deserts." For example, Jamalpur and Netrokona, which once had multiple halls, now have zero active screens.

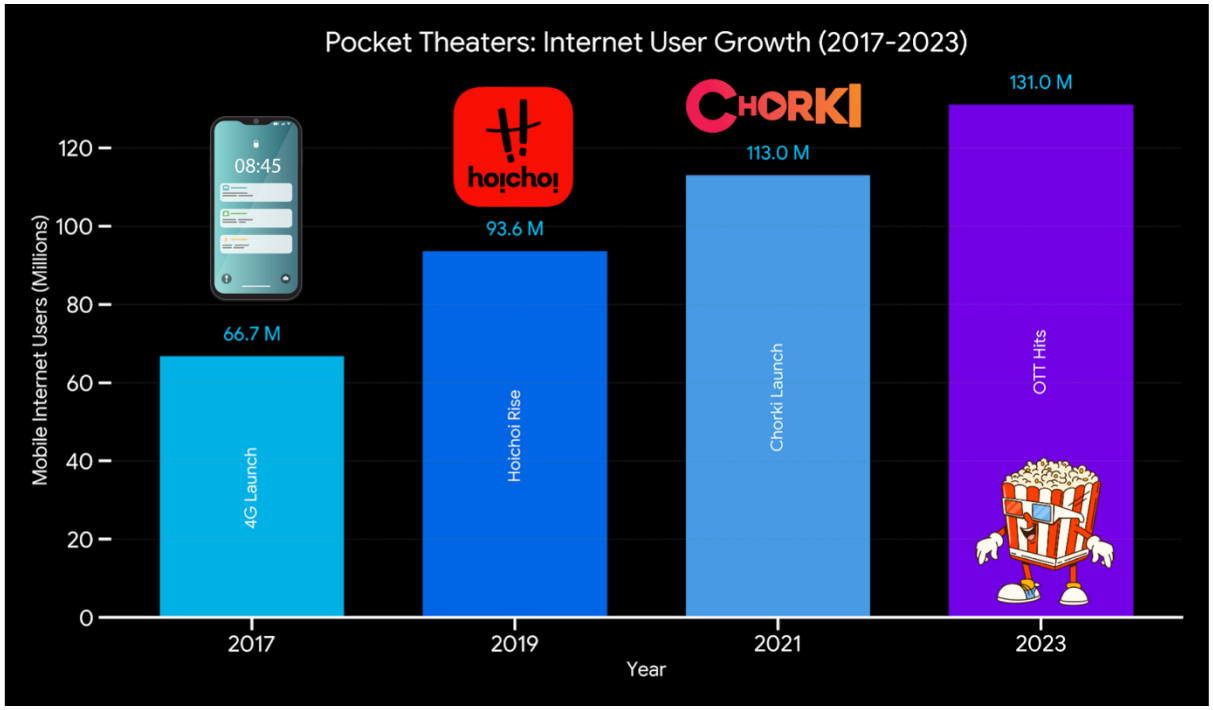


The Gentrification of Price: While halls closed, the cost of the remaining ones skyrocketed.

- Average Ticket (2005): 40 - 60 BDT (Single Screen)
- Average Ticket (2024): 400 - 800 BDT (Multiplex)

This pricing shift pushed the mass audience out of the halls and forced them to look for entertainment elsewhere.

The death of the cinema hall coincided perfectly with the explosion of 4G connectivity and affordable smartphones.



The New Players: Local OTT (Over-The-Top) platforms stepped in to fill the void.

- Chorki: Positioned as the premium storyteller, producing hits like Mahanagar.
- Hoichoi: Tapped into the cross-border Bengali base.
- Bongo: Captured the rural market with a massive library of legacy content.

"The barrier to entry for entertainment dropped from a 500 Taka ticket and a 3-hour traffic jam to a 20 Taka data pack and a single click." - Head of Strategy, Leading Bangladeshi OTT Platform

The transition wasn't accidental. It was driven by four specific socio-economic levers unique to Bangladesh.

1. The "Traffic Tax" In Dhaka, where a 5km commute can take 2 hours, the "opportunity cost" of going to a cinema hall is incredibly high.

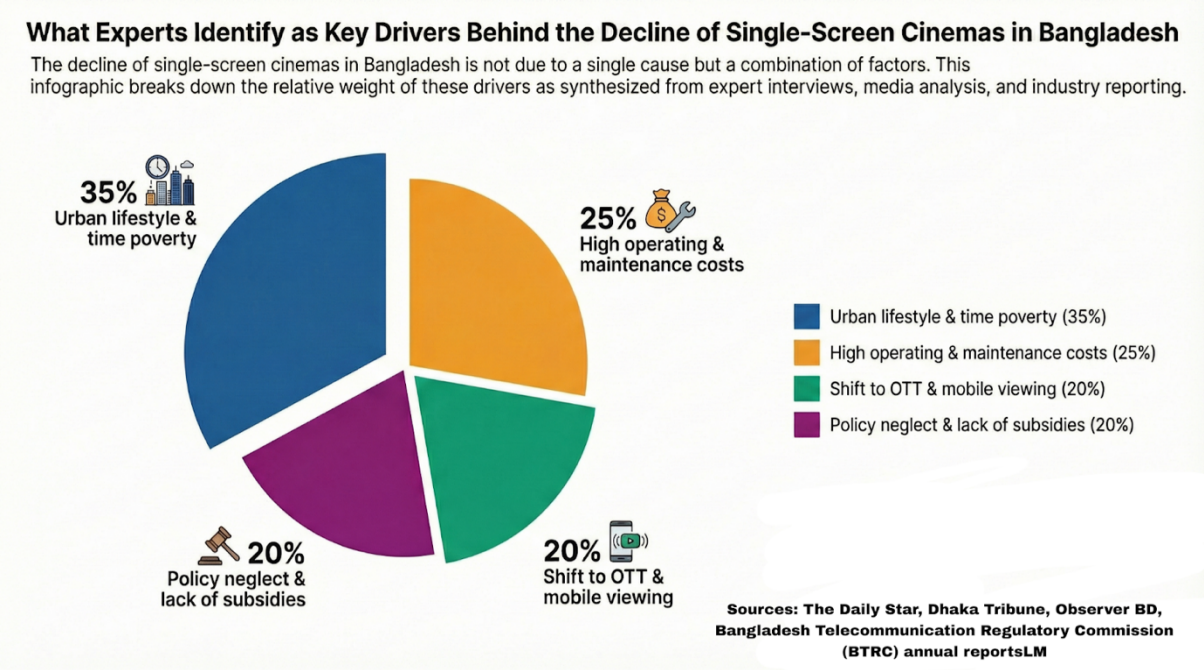
- Cinema: Requires ~4 hours travel time.
- Phone: Requires 0 travel time. In fact, traffic jams have become the prime time for mobile viewing.

2. Content Renaissance Cinema halls were stuck in a loop of repetitive melodrama. OTT platforms invested in "Gritty Realism"- thrillers, dark comedies, and social commentary that resonated with modern youth.

3. Privacy and Safety For many women and families, the deteriorating condition of old cinema halls (hygiene, safety, crowd behavior) made them unappealing. Home viewing offers a controlled, safe environment.

4. The Economics of the "Mini-Pack" Bangladesh is a "sachet economy"- people prefer small, bite-sized payments. OTT platforms adapted by offering daily or weekly subscriptions via mobile balance (Telco billing), mimicking the affordability of a single-screen ticket from the 90s.

Rather than a story of technology killing culture, the experience of the single-screen cinema being diminished in Bangladesh is about neglecting culture, neglecting culture, and altering their lifestyles. There is also the economic pressure.



Film critic and cultural commentator Dr. Anisul Hoque credits the solving of the problem to blaming only the OTT platforms.

“Cinema halls have not been killed by OTT platforms. Urban life did. In the event of lack of time, the ritual is refused in favour of convenience.”

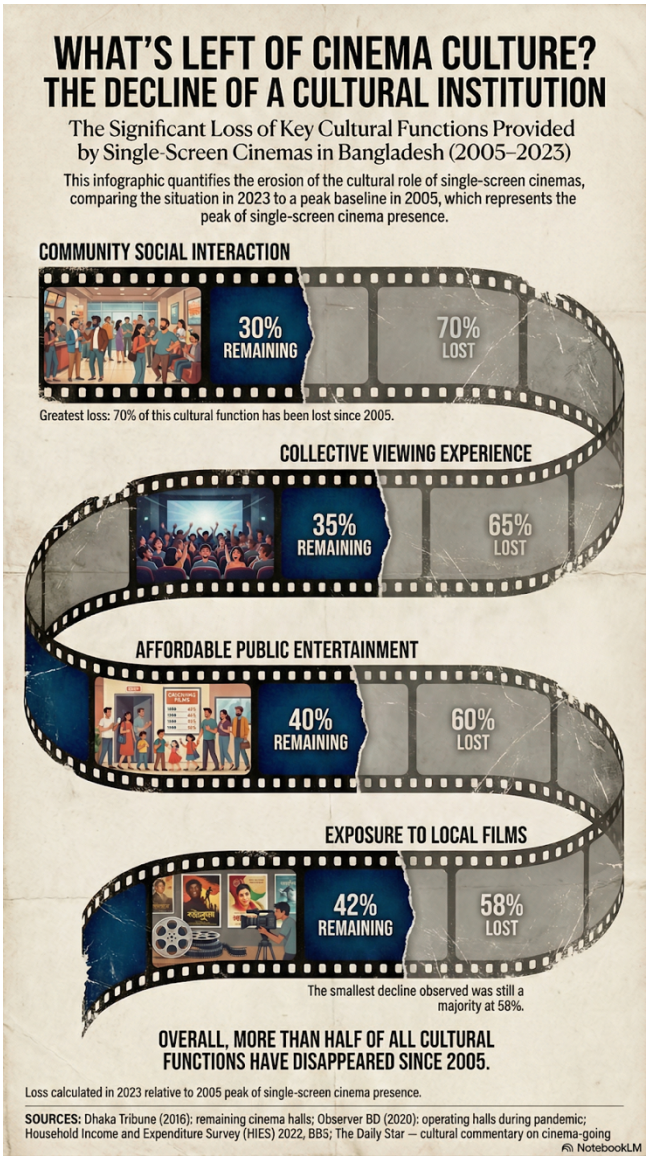
The same is felt by media analysts. The haste urbanization in Bangladesh as they are saying, reformulated the consumption of entertainment and practices in order to scale faster than the infrastructure. The Industry players have argued that single-screen halls failed to maintain content and comfort to the modern audience requirements.

One of the senior executives of one of the OTT platforms in Bangladesh concisely explains the lack of digital services: “people did not cease to love stories. They simply did not have the time, safety, and money to go out on their own behalf. People did not cease to love stories. They simply did not have the time, safety, and money to go out on their behalf.”

There is also a structural view of the debt crisis taken by the cinema hall owners. The Daily Star and Dhaka Tribune interviewed these exhibitors, who cited increasing electricity costs and high taxes, lack of state subsidies, lack of attendance, and decline as reasons they were forced to quit. One of the ex-hall owners of the north part of Bangladesh explained it simply: we were operating buildings of the 1970s, with an audience in the 2020s. The math doesn't work."

It is evident that experts agree on the point that the fall of the single-screen cinemas is hardly complex, was most likely foreseeable, and can be avoided. The truth of the matter though, is that there was no single person who was motivated to intervene.

What Do We Lose When Single Screens Die?



In addition to the physical structures that are merely being shut down, the shutdown of a single-screen cinema represents the closing of theatres.
spin and lacked a cultural warp of togetherness.

1. The Dissolution of the Collective Viewing Experience.

The collective viewing experience is dead, according to the infographic (and is lost by 65 percent).
2005 to the present. Cinema theatres would be utilized as places of emotion. Laughter, terror, excitement, and clapping
hands were shared, and at some point in a performance, the audience was present in their entirety.
social moment. a performance. Watching the performance on an individual device, even with a screen in front of it.
high resolution, will never repeat the social moment.

2. Social interaction deterioration.

The most significant of them is the social impact. The 70 percent are social, according to the infographic.
The associated interaction with the cinema has lost. The one-screen cinemas were used as social media.
socializing in the establishment. Neighbors met, dialogue
started, and a locality was created. Despite the lost theaters, digital interaction still remains. there.

3. Loss of Entertainment

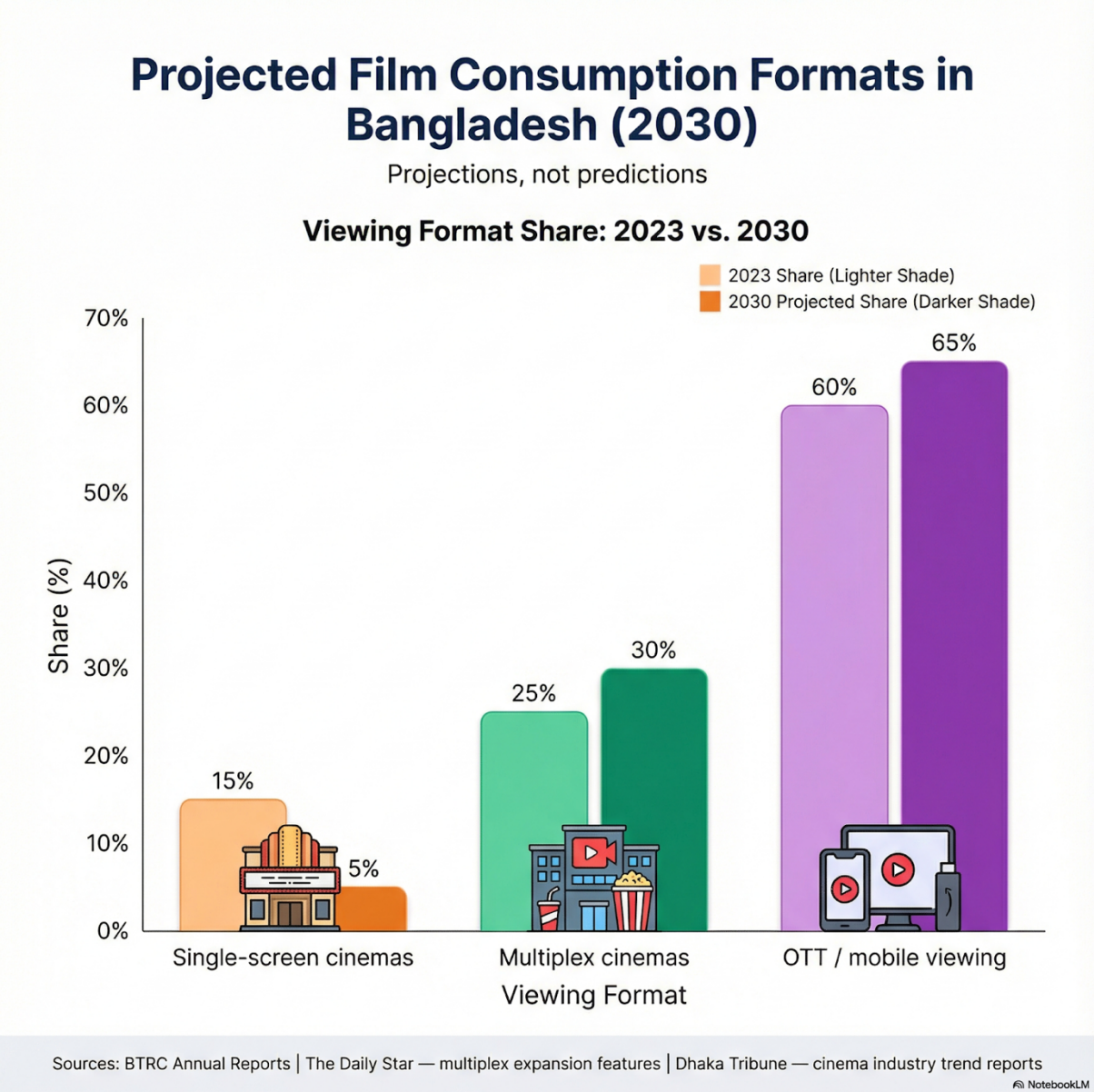
According to the info-graphic, 60 percent of the cheap entertainment is lost. The cinema that was
when a social activity of the entire community has been individualized. The increase in multiplex
pricing is restricted to low socio-economic audiences. This change in the cinema
industry is the loss of a democratic leisure activity.

4. Decline in Availability of home movies.

This is the least amount of exposure that has been reduced, though this is still significant. Exposure to local films has been cut by 58. Historically, the single-screen movies were the largest distributors of Bangladeshi movies in areas that are not in Dhaka. Now they are forced to use OTT algorithms to discover local films, assuming they exist.

This information depicts a tragic fact: within less than 2 decades, more than half of the cultural activities of the cinema have been lost.

The Future of Movie Culture in Bangladesh



The movie culture in Bangladesh has reached the plateau stage after displaying a substantial growth in the past 10 years, although it will not cease to exist. It is evolving.

OTT Market and Movie Culture Projection 2030's claims that it is not a full replacement, but a hybrid future.

Most of the Bangladeshis will be using Smartphones as their major cinema. OTT and mobile viewing are already estimated to increase to 60% in 2023 and 65% in 2030.

Predicted to receive a low 30 percent share, will be urban, high-end, and exclusive to classes, multiplex cinemas will be a feature in Bangladesh.

The single screen cinemas, on the contrary, will fall by, as much as 15 percent, skipping the proposed phase of cultural rejuvenation to just hang around in some rural regions.

According to industry consultants, there is a high probability of an unequal coexistence; the multiplexes that would act as box-office-event spaces, and the OTT platforms would serve up the daily traffic demand of mass entertainment. Single screen cinemas in the rural areas could only survive through government subsidies: reduction of taxes, conversion of community cultural centers, or direct subsidies.

It is not a screen (as the professionals surmise) choice that the future holds; but access to which screen by whom.

In the case of the cinema of Bangladesh, all boils down to compromise.

We lost what we had gained in communion.What we had gained in accessibility we lost in the experience.

Watching a film in Bangladesh does not involve planning, standing in a queue, and being in a company with the other clients. It has become merely a touchscreen, on its own, productive, quiet.

They have not gone anywhere.

However, the relationship we share with cinema has changed.

And in such a transformation, when we suddenly shift a crowd of people out of the theatres and into the comfort of our own screens, we are not merely watching a movie.
We belong to a changed culture.

AI Acknowledgement:
AI tools were used for language editing, structural guidance, and visualization support. All reporting, analysis, and editorial decisions were made by the us.

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